

What else to watch: *The 39 Steps* (1935) ■ *Brighton Rock* (1947) ■ *The Fallen Idol* (1948) ■ *Our Man in Havana* (1959) ■ *The Manchurian Candidate* (1962, p.334) ■ *The Ipcress File* (1965) ■ *The Spy Who Came in from the Cold* (1965)

The screenplay was developed by novelist Graham Greene from his own novella. It came from a simple thought that occurred to Greene: "I saw a man walking down the street whose funeral I had only recently attended." This idea inspired the story of a man who fakes his own death.

The third man

American pulp-fiction author Holly Martins (Joseph Cotten) arrives in a Vienna wrecked and divided by war at the invitation of his old friend Harry Lime, only to find that Lime has been killed by a speeding car just days earlier. At the funeral, Martins meets the two men who were with Lime when he died. He also meets Lime's girlfriend Anna (Alida Valli), with whom he becomes smitten. Together they question the porter at Lime's apartment building, who tells them there was an unknown third man present at the fatal moment.

On Vienna's giant Ferris wheel, known as the Riesenrad, police chief Calloway (Trevor Howard) advises Martins to leave Vienna,

revealing that Lime was a black marketeer who sold adulterated penicillin. Martins visits Anna, who tells him that she might be deported to the Soviet sector of the city. As he leaves, he spots a figure in the shadows. It's Lime.

Martins meets Lime the next day at the Riesenrad, where Lime has invited Martins to join him. Martins, realizing how much his old friend has changed, agrees to help Calloway trap Lime, on the condition that Anna receive safe passage out of Vienna. When Anna refuses to accept the police chief's deal, Calloway takes Martins to a children's hospital to show him the devastation caused by Lime's adulterated penicillin—and »

Lime is cool and calculating, and has disdain for Martins' moralistic view of the world. In Lime's cynical opinion, there are no heroes in the real world.

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Has there ever been a film where the music more perfectly suited the action than in Carol Reed's *The Third Man*?

Roger Ebert

Chicago Sun-Times, 1996

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